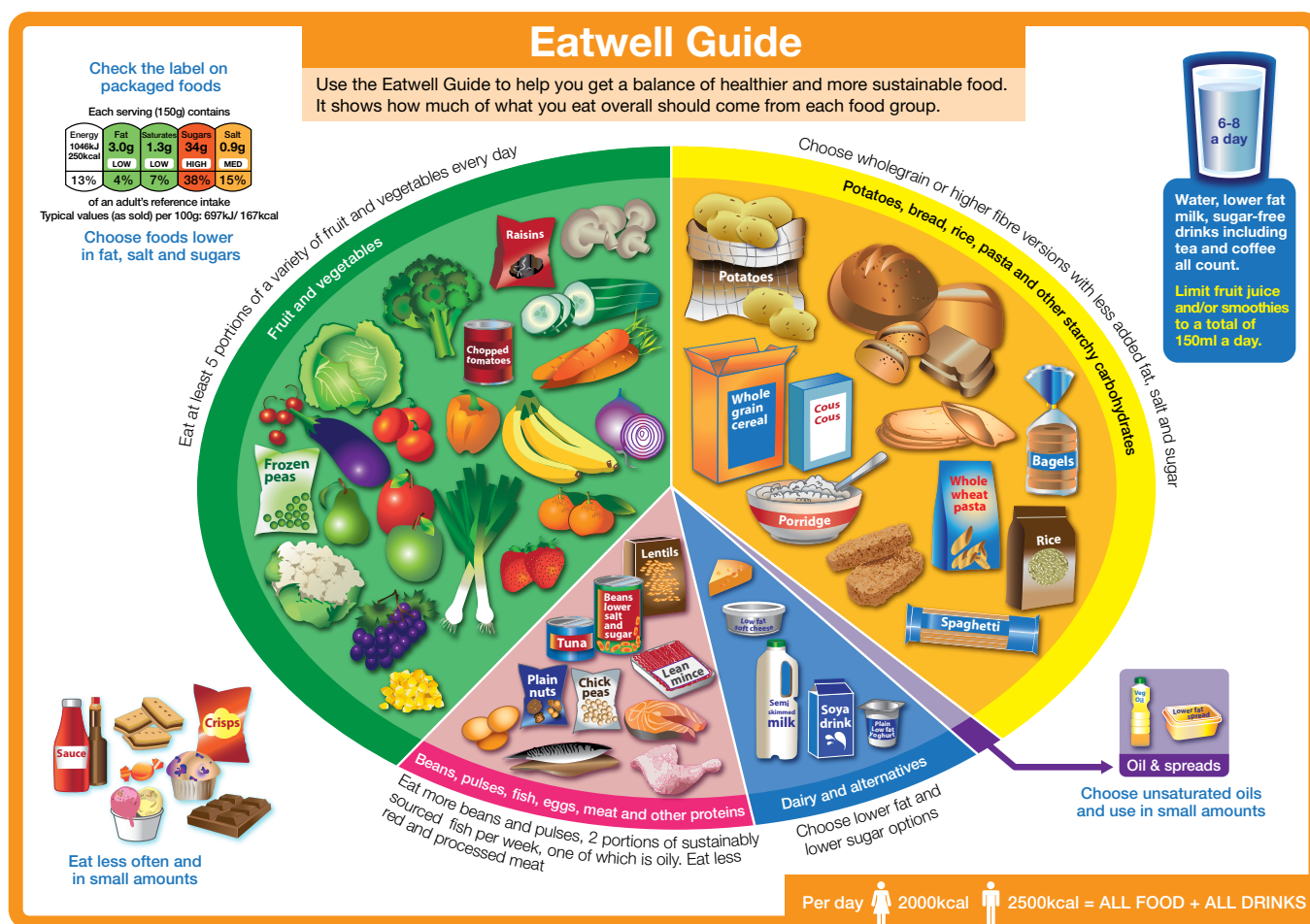




The Eatwell Guide

Helping you eat a healthy, balanced diet



Source: Public Health England in association with the Welsh Government, Food Standards Scotland and the Food Standards Agency in Northern Ireland

Get started now

Eating well and having a healthy lifestyle can help us feel our best – and make a big difference to our long-term health. So why not make a change today?

The Eatwell Guide shows the proportions in which different types of foods are needed to have a well-balanced and healthy diet. The proportions shown are representative of your food consumption over the period of a day or even a week, not necessarily each meal time.

Is the Eatwell Guide for me?

The Eatwell Guide applies to most people regardless of weight, dietary restrictions/ preferences or ethnic origin.

However, it doesn't apply to children under 2 because they have different nutritional needs. Between the ages of 2 and 5, children should gradually move to eating the same foods as the rest of the family, in the proportions shown on the Eatwell Guide. Anyone with special dietary requirements or medical needs might want to check with a registered dietitian on how to adapt the Eatwell Guide to meet their individual needs.

How can the Eatwell Guide help?

The Eatwell Guide shows the different types of foods and drinks we should consume – and in what proportions – to have a healthy, balanced diet.

The Eatwell Guide shows the proportions of the main food groups that form a healthy, balanced diet:

- Eat at least 5 portions of a variety of fruit and vegetables every day
- Base meals on potatoes, bread, rice, pasta or other starchy carbohydrates; choosing wholegrain versions where possible
- Have some dairy or dairy alternatives (such as soya drinks); choosing lower fat and lower sugar options
- Eat some beans, pulses, fish, eggs, meat and other proteins (including 2 portions of fish every week, one of which should be oily)
- Choose unsaturated oils and spreads and eat in small amounts
- Drink 6-8 cups/glasses of fluid a day

If consuming foods and drinks high in fat, salt or sugar have these less often and in small amounts.

When should I use the Eatwell Guide?

You can use the Eatwell Guide to help you make healthier choices whenever you're:

- deciding what to eat
- at home cooking
- out shopping for groceries
- eating out in a restaurant, cafe or canteen
- choosing food on the go

Aim to fill your trolley with a healthy balance of different types of food.

How does it work?

The Eatwell Guide divides the foods and drinks we consume into five main groups. Try to choose a variety of different foods from each of the groups to help you get the wide range of nutrients your body needs to stay healthy and work properly.

It is important to get some fat in the diet, however, foods high in fat, salt and sugar are placed outside of the main image as these types of foods are not essential in the diet and most of us need to cut down on these to achieve our healthy balance. Unsaturated fats from plant sources, for example vegetable oil or olive oil, are healthier types of fat. But remember, all types of fat are high in energy and so should only be eaten in small amounts.

Many of the foods we eat, such as pizzas, casseroles, pasta dishes and sandwiches, are combination foods and contain ingredients from more than one of the food groups. For these sorts of food, you just need to work out the main ingredients and think about how these fit with the sections on the guide. For example, if you're having a cottage pie: the potato fits into the yellow segment; the milk in the mashed potato fits into the blue segment, the spread in the mashed potato fits into the purple segment, the meat, meat substitute or beans would fall into the pink segment; the onion, carrots and peas would fit into the green segment.

Let's take a closer look at each of the food groups...

A closer look at

Fruit and vegetables

Most people know we should be eating more fruit and veg, but many of us aren't eating enough. Fruit and veg should make up just over a third of the food we eat each day.

Aim to eat at least five portions of a variety of fruit and veg each day. If you count how many portions you're having, it might help you increase the amount and variety of fruit and veg you eat. Choose from fresh, frozen, canned, dried or juiced. A portion is 80g or any of these: 1 apple, banana, pear, orange or other similar-size fruit, 3 heaped tablespoons of vegetables, a dessert bowl of salad, 30g of dried fruit (which should be kept to mealtimes) or a 150ml glass of fruit juice or smoothie (counts as a maximum of one portion a day).



A closer look at

Potatoes, bread, rice, pasta and other starchy carbohydrates

Starchy food is a really important part of a healthy diet and should make up just over a third of the food we eat. Choose higher-fibre, wholegrain varieties when you can by purchasing wholewheat pasta, brown rice, or simply leaving the skins on potatoes.

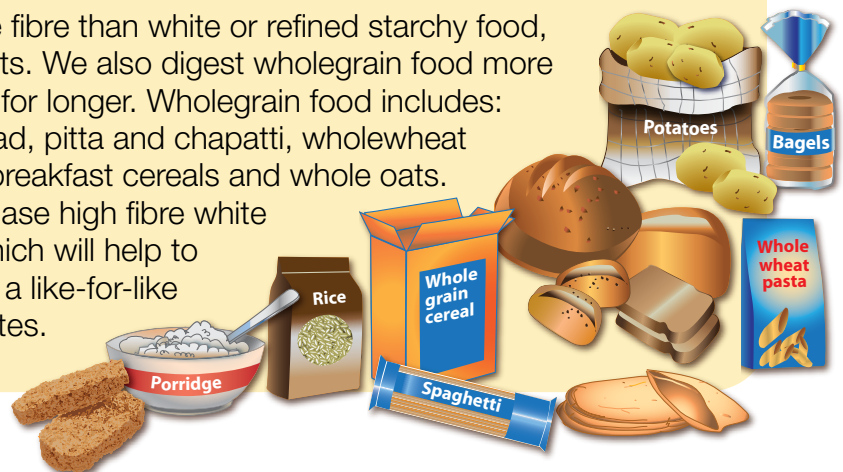
Base your meals around starchy carbohydrate foods. So, you could:

- start the day with a wholegrain breakfast cereal; choose one lower in salt and sugars
- have a sandwich for lunch
- round off the day with potatoes, pasta or rice as a base for your evening meal

Some people think starchy food is fattening, but gram for gram it contains less than half the calories of fat. You just need to watch the fats you add when you're cooking and serving this sort of food, because that's what increases the calorie content.

Why choose wholegrain?

Wholegrain food contains more fibre than white or refined starchy food, and often more of other nutrients. We also digest wholegrain food more slowly so it can help us feel full for longer. Wholegrain food includes: wholemeal and wholegrain bread, pitta and chapatti, wholewheat pasta, brown rice, wholegrain breakfast cereals and whole oats. Remember, you can also purchase high fibre white versions of bread and pasta which will help to increase your fibre intake using a like-for-like substitute of your family favourites.



A closer look at

Dairy and alternatives

Try to have some milk and dairy food (or dairy alternatives) – such as cheese, yoghurt and fromage frais.

These are good sources of protein and vitamins, and they're also an important source of calcium, which helps to keep our bones strong. Some dairy food can be high in fat and saturated fat, but there are plenty of lower-fat options to choose from.

Go for lower fat and lower sugar products where possible. For example, why not try 1% fat milk which contains about half the fat of semi-skimmed milk without a noticeable change in taste or texture? Or reduced fat cheese which is also widely available. Or you could have just a smaller amount of the full-fat varieties less often. When buying dairy alternatives, go for unsweetened, calcium-fortified versions.



A closer look at

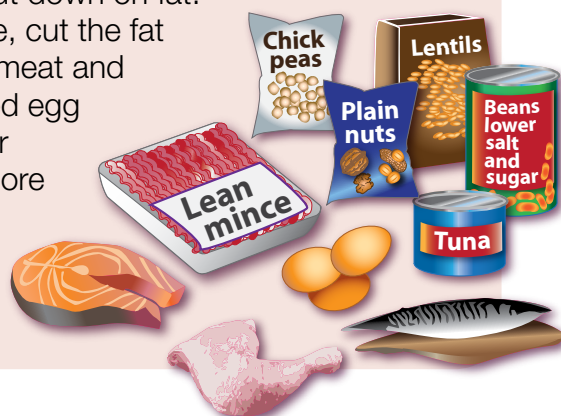
Beans, pulses, fish, eggs, meat and other proteins

These foods are sources of protein, vitamins and minerals, so it is important to eat some foods from this group.

Beans, peas and lentils (which are all types of pulses) are good alternatives to meat because they're naturally very low in fat, and they're high in fibre, protein, vitamins and minerals. Pulses, or legumes as they are sometimes called, are edible seeds that grow in pods and include foods like lentils, chickpeas, beans and peas. Other vegetable-based sources of protein include tofu, bean curd and mycoprotein; all of which are widely available in most retailers.

Aim for at least two portions (2 x 140g) of fish a week, including a portion of oily fish. Most people should be eating more fish, but there are recommended limits for oily fish, crab and some types of white fish. For more information on fish please see www.nhs.uk/Livewell/Goodfood/Pages/fish-shellfish. Also www.msc.org/ for more guidance on sustainably sourced fish.

Some types of meat are high in fat, particularly saturated fat. So when you're buying meat, remember that the type of cut or meat product you choose, and how you cook it, can make a big difference. To cut down on fat: choose lean cuts of meat and go for leaner mince, cut the fat off of meat and the skin off of chicken, try to grill meat and fish instead of frying and have a boiled or poached egg instead of fried. If you eat more than 90g of red or processed meat per day, try to cut down to no more than 70g per day. The term processed meat includes sausages, bacon, cured meats and reformed meat products.



A closer look at

Oils and spreads

Although some fat in the diet is essential, generally we are eating too much saturated fat and need to reduce our consumption.

Unsaturated fats are healthier fats that are usually from plant sources and in liquid form as oil, for example vegetable oil, rapeseed oil and olive oil. Swapping to unsaturated fats will help to reduce cholesterol in the blood, therefore it is important to get most of our fat from unsaturated oils.

Choosing lower fat spreads, as opposed to butter, is a good way to reduce your saturated fat intake.

Remember that all types of fat are high in energy and should be limited in the diet.

